This book was written by me in Ahmadnagar Fort prison during the five months, April to September 1944. Some of my colleagues in prison were good enough to read the manuscript and make a n u m b e r of valuable suggestions. On revising the book in prison I took advantage of these suggestions and m a d e some additions. No one, I need hardly add, is responsible for w h a t I have written or necessarily agrees with it. But I must express my deep gratitude to my fellow-prisoners in Ahmadnagar Fort for the innumerable talks and discussions we had, which helped me greatly to clear my o w n mind about various aspects of Indian history and culture. Prison is not a pleasant place to live in even for a short period, m u c h less for long years. But it was a privilege for me to live in close contact with m e n of outstanding ability and culture and a wide h u m a n outlook which even the passions of the moment did not obscure.

My eleven companions in Ahmadnagar Fort were an interesting cross-section of India and represented in their several ways not only politics b u t Indian scholarship, old a n d new, and various aspects of present-day India. Nearly all t h e principal living I n d i a n languages, as well as the classical languages which have